

# Micro Space Empire Battles

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This is a low complexity tactical space combat game for player vs player ship dueling. Highlights include a semi-random impulsive movement system and energy allocation using tokens.

Players will find some similarities to games like *Star Fleet Battles*, but this game is vastly simpler, while still giving players interesting tactical decisions that they will need to make.

## Overview

Each turn players allocate energy from their engines to movement, weapons and shields. Ships then move around the map using a semi-variable impulse system for twelve impulses, and fire at each other until the other player has been defeated.

### SHIPS

Ships have engines, weapons, and shields. The engines generate power each turn that is used to power weapons and shields each turn.

Each ship has its own player mat which shows its weapons, energy, hull, etc. These are represented as a series of boxes, with cubes used to indicate charged weapons, damage, speed, etc. As the ship takes damage, the damaged systems are marked using red cubes.

If the hull is destroyed (all hull boxes have a red damage cube on them), the ship is immediately destroyed.

### WEAPONS

There are three types of weapons in this game – beam, mass driver and missile. The first two are fired directly at an enemy ship and resolved using a die roll. Missiles are seeking weapons that are placed on the map and physically move towards an enemy ship.

Beam weapons are more accurate and do more damage but require more energy and have a shorter range than mass drivers. Missile weapons require no energy, but have limited ammunition.

## Setup

Both players select one or two ships to play against each other. Players should agree what type of ships to play. Generally speaking you should both take ships of the same size. If you play with two or more ships per player, I recommend treating small ships as 2 points, medium ships as 3 points and large ships as 4 points for play balancing purposes.

A hexagonal map no larger than 20x20 rows/columns should be used. Counters to represent ships will be needed, as well as blue, red and yellow cubes to represent energy, damage, and shields, respectively. You will also need some counters to represent missiles if your ship has a missile launcher.

The player's ships should start no more than 15 hexes apart, and should generally be facing each other.

Place one yellow cube in each shield box. Place one blue marker in each engine box. If the ship you are playing has missile launchers, place 3 missile tokens for each launcher.

## Allocate Energy

Each ship generates a set amount of energy depending on its engines. As described in the setup, each of your engine boxes has a blue power cube on it. You then use these cubes to allocate energy to movement, weapons or shield reinforcement. Simply move the blue cubes to the appropriate space on your ship display to indicate how you wish to spend it this turn. This allocation is secret and should be hidden until both players are done.

The amount of energy you allocate for movement will determine your speed for the upcoming movement phase. Allocating energy for weapons will allow you to fire that weapon in the upcoming turn. The amount of energy required to charge a weapon depends on the type of weapon, except missiles, which do not require energy.

The energy you allocate to shield reinforcement will help prevent damage in the upcoming turn. Note that the maximum amount you may allocate to shield reinforcement is noted on your ship display.

Once both players have allocated their energy, energy allocation becomes public knowledge. Announce your ship speeds. You are now ready to start the turn, roll for initiative, and begin movement.

Note that you are not obligated to allocate all energy. Any unused energy is simply lost.

## Initiative

Both players roll 1d6 for initiative. High roll wins. Re-roll any ties.

Initiative is only used in certain circumstances, such as announcing weapons fire, and deciding who moves first when ships are moving at the same speed.

## Movement

Movement is controlled by a deck of cards that indicate which speeds move that round. Each round within a turn is called an "impulse".

The movement cards are split into 3 piles of 4 cards each, and each pile represents a phase. For the first 4 impulses draw from the Phase 1 pile. For the next 4 impulses draw from the Phase 2 pile. For the last 4 impulses draw from the Phase 3 pile.

Each card has a series of numbers on them. Every ship moving at a speed that matches one of the numbers that appears on the card that is drawn either moves one hex or turns sixty degrees, starting with the slowest ship. In the case of a tie, the side with the initiative decides which ship(s) move first.

A ship may move a maximum of speed 12. Missiles move at speed 24, i.e. two moves per impulse, and must always move and/or turn towards their target. Ships and missiles may only move forwards, never backwards.

*Designer's Note: The goal here is to prevent the excessive precision of an impulsive movement chart that lets players hyper analyze every possible movement combination at any given moment. The semi-variable card system is meant to provide more of a real time feel by preventing such analysis in the first place and to simulate the occasionally unexpected maneuver.*

## TURN MODE

Each ship has a "turn mode", the number of hexes it must move forward before it can turn. This is determined by the ship's size and speed. Small ships have a turn mode of 0 at speeds 1-4, 1 at speeds 5-8 and 2 at speeds 9-12. Medium ships have a turn mode of 1, 2 and 3, respectively at the same speeds. Large ships have a turn mode of 2, 3, and 4, respectively at the same speeds. This is also indicated on the ship display for easy reference.

Missiles have a turn mode of 0.

*Note that ships with a turn mode of 0 could continue to turn in place without actually moving forward!*

## SIDE SLIPPING

Ships may move 60 degrees to either side while retaining the same facing instead of moving straight forward or turning. This is called "side slipping". A ship may not sideslip twice in a row. This still counts as forward movement for satisfying turn mode.

*This abstractly represents more granular turns, as the hexagonal map otherwise prevents it.*

## RESTRICTIONS

A ship may not move into the same hex as another ship. It must move to a different space (or turn) if possible, even if it must use the special maneuver token to do so. If it is not possible to avoid moving into the same hex for any reason then the ship does not move that impulse and its movement is "lost".

A missile may enter the same hex as another ship, or another missile. If it enters the hex of its target, it immediately causes damage to it.

## SPECIAL MANEUVERS

Each small and medium ship has a "special maneuver" token. When used, the ship may make a special maneuver during the movement phase. It may be used at any time during the impulse before or after movement. If both players wish to use their special maneuvers at the same time, the player with the initiative decides who uses it first.

There are three possible maneuvers a ship may make when using the token.

Option #1 – Bootlegger. This option allows you to rotate the ship in any direction before or after movement is completed for the impulse, ignoring all normal movement restrictions.

Option #2 – Quick Stop. This option lets your ship come to a complete stop. The ship does not move for the rest of the turn.

Option #3 – Emergency Power. This option lets you immediately take an extra move.

Once the special maneuver token has been used, the ship may not make any more special maneuvers for the rest of the game.

## Weapons

Both beam and mass driver weapons have a short, medium and long range. For beam weapons, short range is 1-3 hexes, medium range is 4-6 hexes, and long range is 7-9 hexes. For mass drivers, short range is 1-4 hexes, medium range is 5-8 hexes, and long range is 9-12 hexes. Missiles have unlimited range.

Beam weapons require two points of power per weapon to fire, while mass drivers require 1 point of power per weapon to fire.

Missiles require no power to launch, and all unfired missiles are destroyed if their launcher takes one point of damage. There are no “secondary explosions” in this game if there were still missiles in the launcher when it was destroyed.

### WEAPONS FIRE

At the end of each impulse, after ships have moved, announce which weapons you are firing, and at which ship. Each weapon may be fired once per turn, and only if it was powered.

If necessary, the player with the initiative determines who announces first. When you fire a beam or mass driver, remove the allocated energy cubes for that weapon to indicate that it has been fired, and put them to the side for now.

Missiles are launched first before beam or mass driver weapons. Put any launched missiles in the same hex as the launching ship, and announce their target. Missiles may only target ships, not other missiles.

Now fire beam and mass driver weapons. First determine the range, including the hex of the target. Do not include the hex of the firing ship when determining the range. Once the range is established, determine the number on a d6 need to hit your target.

Note that you can target missiles with beam or mass driver weapons, including those just launched.

### HITTING YOUR OPPONENT

Roll a die for each beam or mass driver weapon to see if it scored a hit.

For beam weapons, you need a 2 or greater at short range, a 3 or greater at medium range and a 4 or greater at long range. The amount of damage a beam weapon does when it hits depends on the range to its target. At short range it does 3 points of damage, at medium range it does 2 points of damage, and at long range it does 1 point of damage.

For mass drivers, you need a 3 or greater at short range, a 4 or greater at medium range, and a 5 or greater at long range. A mass driver always does 2 points of damage when it hits, regardless of the range.

Both beam and mass driver weapons may fire at a missile. If hit at any range by either type of weapon, the missile is destroyed.

Missiles immediately cause 3 points of damage if they enter the hex of their target.

## FIRING ARCS

Beam and Mass Driver weapons have up to four possible firing arcs that indicate where that particular weapon may fire. If your target is not within the arc of the weapon, it may not fire at the target. Some weapons may have multiple firing arcs.

The four possible arcs are Front (the 3 hexes directly in front of the ship), Left (the 3 hexes extending from the left side of the ship), Right (the 3 hexes extending from the right side of the ship) or Aft (the 3 hexes directly behind the ship). From the 3 initial hexes, the arc then extends indefinitely. These are abbreviated as “F”, “L”, “R” or “A”, respectively, or some combination of these letters, next to each weapon on your ship’s display.

These arcs overlap to some degree, as the front left hex extending from a ship is both within the Front and Left firing arc, for example. Some weapons have multiple arcs, or may have a 360 degree firing arc.

Missiles are always considered to have a 360 degree firing arc, and may be launched at a target regardless of its relative position to the launching ship.

*Side note: these are 120 degree arcs, equivalent to the FA, L, R and RA arcs from Star Fleet Battles for those familiar with that system.*

## Shields

Your ship is protected by shields that will be whittled away as your ship is hit by enemy weapons. As your shields are damaged, remove a yellow cube for each point of damage it takes. Once your shields are gone, your ship starts to take damage.

Each ship has two shields – a front shield and a rear shield. The maximum strength of each shield is represented by the number of boxes on your ship display. You do not need to explicitly power your shields unless you want to reinforce them. They are always up, assuming they haven’t been destroyed by enemy fire.

At the start of each turn you may allocate energy to reinforce a shield. Each point of energy will absorb one point of damage if that shield is hit by a weapon during the upcoming turn, preventing the shield itself from taking damage. You cannot reinforce a destroyed shield – it must have at least one point left to reinforce it.

The maximum you may reinforce a shield depends on its size class. A small ship may spend a maximum of 1 point of energy to reinforce either (or both) shields, a medium ship may spend up to 2 points, and a large ship may spend up to 3 points.

If at least one of your shield boxes has been destroyed in a previous turn you may spend two points of energy (during energy allocation) to repair a shield box. At the end of the turn, repair one shield box of your choice (front or rear).

## SHIELD FACING

When an enemy weapon hits your ship through the front half of your ship, apply damage to your ship's front shield. If hit through the rear half of your ship, apply damage to the rear shield. If it's on a hex boundary directly between front and back, the player with the initiative chooses which shield is hit.

## Damage

Any weapons that penetrate an enemy ship's shields will damage the ship. For each point of damage that penetrates a shield, roll a die. On a 1-3, apply the damage to the hull. On a 4-5, apply the damage to the engines. On a 6, apply the damage to a weapon, owning player's choice.

For each point of damage, place a red cube on the ship's box to indicate that it is damaged. For engines, this means replacing a blue cube.

A single point of damage on a weapon knocks that weapon out for the rest of the game. Note that beam weapons have two boxes for energy allocation, but it only requires a single hit to destroy it.

## End of Turn

At the end of the 12<sup>th</sup> impulse, the turn ends. Collect all power cubes that were allocated and place them back on your engines on any box that hasn't been damaged, i.e. has a red damage cube on it.

If you put energy into repairing shields, repair one shield box of your choice now by placing a yellow cube in the box.

You are now ready to begin a new turn.

## Victory

Each player score points for damaging or destroying enemy ships. You receive 1 VP per hull point damaged. You receive an additional 1, 2 or 3 VP for each small, medium or large ship that you destroy, respectively.

The player that scores the most points wins the battle. If there is a tie, the player with at least one ship still on the map wins. If both players have at least one ship still on the map, the game is a draw.

If a ship leaves the map for any reason it is considered destroyed for victory purposes.

## Optional Rules

### ACCELERATION/DECELERATION

Each ship is limited to how much it may increase or decrease speed between turns. The maximum speed change is limited to 5, 4 and 3 for small, medium and large ships, respectively. You may set your speed to whatever you wish on turn 1.

## WEAPON REPAIR

You may spend three points of energy to repair a beam or mass driver weapon during the energy allocation phase. It may not be fired the turn it was repaired. Missile launchers may not be repaired.

## Sequence of Play

1. Allocate energy – Each ship secretly allocates its energy between weapons, movement and shields.
2. Announce speed – Announce the speed of each ship and make note of it.
3. Roll for initiative. High roll wins, re-roll ties.
4. Activity Segment
  - a. Draw a movement card and move ships and missiles.
  - b. Launch missiles.
  - c. Fire beam and mass driver weapons.
  - d. Repeat until there are no more movement cards to draw.
5. Check victory conditions.
6. Remove all allocation markers. Begin next turn.